Don't Encourage Him

By Jason Taylor

JASON: **(Pg 123-142)** When I was six years old, I was walking through the woods behind my parents' house, when I came across this tiny lump of fur. *(kneels)* When I bend down to take a real good look, I can see that it's a tiny baby rabbit. Just lookin' up at me. Then my father's voice went off in my head: "If you find a baby animal in the wild, don't touch it. You'll leave human scent on it, and its mother will smell it and won't take care of it anymore, and it'll die." But I was only six and I thought, "Maybe if I just touch him once . . . just real quick, maybe I won't leave any scent on him." So I reached down and touched him once . . . just a quick stroke across the back . . . and I realize he's just as soft as I thought.

So, before I know it, I'm holding him, cradled in my arms, stroking him across the back . . . and I suddenly get this horrible, deep, remorseful feeling in my stomach because I realize that I probably just killed him. At six years old that's pretty hard to deal with. I took him home and looked for anywhere on the farm where I could hide him. . . when I saw the chicken coop. For the next month I volunteered to do all the chicken chores in hopes that no one would find my stupid mistake. And the most amazing thing happened.

My rabbit stopped sleeping in the corner by himself and started sleeping with the hens. Then, he started playing with the chicks. He even started eating chicken feed and I thought, "Wow! Maybe he's not going to die because of my stupid mistake." But as soon as it started, it stopped. He stopped playing and he stopped eating, and he started sleeping in the corner again . . . alone . . . growing skinnier and skinnier. He was going to die for sure.

My mother took one look at him and said, "Jason, you have to let him go." That sick feeling in the pit of my stomach told me that she was right. So I gathered up my rabbit and took him to the exact spot where I'd found him. That sick feeling in my stomach was replaced by pride – pride that I'd done the right thing by letting him go. And just when I was feeling my proudest, I see my brother coming back from a hunting trip. He's got a gun in his right hand and in his left

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. . . by his hind legs . . . he's got my rabbit!

CHRIS: Jason! Come here! Today you're going to be a man . . . today, I'm gonna show you how to skin and clean and cook a rabbit.

JASON: That night at the dinner table I didn't say a word, didn't shed a tear. I didn't want my family to think I couldn't handle it. So, I sat there with my family and I helped them eat the one I loved. And you know what? *(Sour look is replaced with a grin)* It tasted just like chicken!

INTRODUCTION

Who is the person you'll probably know the longest in your life? Yep, it's your sister or your brother. You live together, play together, party together, eat together, laugh together and fight together. Some brothers have terrific, sharing relationships with each other and are the closest of friends. On the other hand, some brothers can infuriate each other.

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JASON: A lot of people tell me about their horrible upbringings. How they grew up in Chicago, or Detroit or New York, and I have to think that I'm right up there with them . . . because I grew up on a farm with **brothers** -- [which] gives you a slightly better survival rate that growing up in England during the plague.

I had two brothers, Jon and Chris. Jon was too young to get into the battles that my older brother and I got into. My older brother was the master. He'd developed his strategy into two different personalities. On the one hand, he was Chris! My Brother! My Blood! My best friend in the entire world! But that was countered with, *(evil grin)* Chris! The Assassin! The man who would do anything to make sure I didn't reach eighteen! This one time, I was watching television, when I hear my brother's voice from upstairs.

CHRIS: Jason! Come upstairs! I want to play with you!

JASON: *(clasps hands with a boyish grin)* Wow! My brother wants to play with me? I must be the luckiest guy in the world! So I was halfway up the stairs when all of a sudden, Chris – my brother, my blood, my best friend -- disappears *(evil grin)* And Chris the assassin is waiting for me with one of those great big, five-pound, nine-volt batteries. You know what I'm talking about? And he drops it -- BANG! Right on my head *(smacks his hand against his head and falls*

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to the floor) Knocking me out instantly. I woke up a few minutes later *(groggily rises)* I'm not sure how long it was, I couldn't tell time yet – and I see the battery on the floor and it has a dent in it this big. *(shows measurement with hand, then holds measurement up to his head)* And my head has a bump on it just the size of the dent.

So I pick up the battery and run to my mom. "Mom! Mom! Chris took this battery and threw it off the top of the stairs and it hit me in the head and made this huge dent!" My mom takes the battery, takes one look at the dent . . . and I swear to God on a stack of Bibles, she says, "If your head had made a dent that big, you'd be dead right now."

But the worst thing my brother ever did to me wasn't physical. It was mental. And it happened one morning [on the bus]. Out of the corner of my eye [I saw him] -- Toby Cartwright, the dumbest fifth-grader in the history of fifth-graders, already has his lunch open and he's eating it at seven-thirty in the morning. But before I can look away, Toby sees me looking at him.

TOBY: *(Leans over chewing open-mouthed and holding an imaginary sandwich)* What did you bring for lunch?

JASON: So I look to my brother for help. MY BROTHER – MY BLOOD – MY ONLY FRIEND ON THIS TRAVELING FREAK SHOW *(to Chris)* Chris! What do I do? Toby's talking to me! *(to audience)* But suddenly he's not Chris my brother anymore . . . SUDDENLY he's CHRIS THE STRANGER who just happened to get on the bus with me and now stares out the window blankly, basically telling me that if anything does down, I'm on my own. So I look back at Toby

TOBY: What did you bring for lunch?

JASON: I'm not allowed to open my lunch till lunchtime.

TOBY: Says who?

JASON: Says the teacher, I guess.

TOBY: So who is she to tell you when you can or can't eat your own lunch?

JASON: *(cocks head and looks out over audience as if deep in thought)* And the was the deepest thing I'd ever heard my entire life. I was only like eight. I hadn't heard very many things. Don't run with scissors, don't play with fire, pants before shoes . . . and "Who is she to tell you when

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you can or can't eat your own lunch?" So I ate it! Oh, yeah! I opened it up and scarfed the sandwich and the chips and sucked down my juice box, and I thought, "THIS TASTES BETTER AT 8 AM THAN IT EVER TASTED AT NOON!"

Of course, noon rolled around and I was hungrier than *anything*! And Toby Cartwright was fine because he'd probably spent the whole morning eating paste and crayons! So I go to my brother. *(to Chris with sad, forlorn look)* Chris, can I have a carrot stick? I ate my lunch on the bus today.

CHRIS: You stupid idiot! [You listened to] Toby Cartwright? He's 16 and still in the fifth-grade! He wears a stocking cap 365 days a year! No, you can't have a carrot stick! Get away from me!

JASON: You know what? I wouldn't have eaten my lunch today if you'd just said something. If you'd just sitck up for me like a brother's supposed to. If you'd just told Toby to leave me alone. But you didn't. You didn't say a word. You abandoned me on the bus. You abandoned me, Chris. And I'm gonna get you back. *(looks to audience with the evil grin)* You wanna know what I did? Do you wanna? Well, one morning while I was watching Pee Wee's Playhouse . . . I cut his finger off! *(laughs demonically)*

I used to run downstairs every Saturday morning and turn the TV on and just go crazy. I thought Pee Wee Herman was a genius! But one morning, just before Pee Wee's Playhouse started, Chris hit me with a pillow. *(as if he's just been hit)* BANG!

CHRIS: If you were in the army, you'd be dead right now!

JASON: Knock it off! Pee Wee's about to start! *(to audience)* But he does it again – BANG! *(to Chris)* If you don't knock it off, I'm gonna kick your butt. *(to audience)* But just when I turn my head to watch, he hits me for the third time . . . BANG! So I grab a pillow of my own and chase him up the stairs. [I turn to get back to my show] and with every ounce of my tiny muscles, I slammed the door as hard as I could – *(slams imaginary door)* WHAM! *(walks away smiling)*

CHRIS: *(blood curdling scream)* I open the door and Chris is holding his bloody hand *(demonstrates)* And I think, "That's odd. I wonder why Chris' hand is all bloody." So I look down and mashed to the door frame *(holds up index finger)* is the index finger of his left hand . . . pointing at ME! *(moves finger as if it's talking)* "Jason . . . Jason . . . why did you sever me,

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Jason? *(to finger)* I don't know, Chris' finger. I'm sorry. I didn't mean to. *(to audience)* My dad burst through the door. He sees the finger and says

DAD: WHAT THE HELL ARE YOU PLAYIN' IN HERE?

JASON: Dad, Dad! I'm sorry. I slammed Chris' finger in the door and accidentally cut it off! *(to audience) So* he grabs my brother by the collar . . . and he PEELS the finger off the door frame and shoves it in his pocket with some ice and he drives to the hospital where they finally sewed it back on after four hours of surgery. *(examines finger)* And it grew back kind of funny. The nail's all crooked, but it looks pretty good considering *(evil assassin grin)* Considering it was slammed in a doorway and separated from his body for four hours! Ha! Ha! Ha! Jason the assassin strikes back!

It may have been the greatest mistake I ever made. For the rest of my life and I'll never be able to admit any minor discomfort without being reminded about how bad that finger hurt. I could be on my deathbed with malaria and say, "Chris . . . could you get me a glass of water?" And he'd say,

CHRIS: Boy! That malaria looks pretty bad. But I bet it doesn't hurt as bad as the time you cut my finger off! Get your own water! Malaria boy!

JASON: This one time, Chris is building his model airplane kit and he needs to solder the engine together, which entails dripping molten metal onto solid metal in order to attach the pieces, and he says -

CHRIS: Jason! Come here! *(places the engine in Jason's hands)* Hold this. And don't move, 'cause if you move and I drip some on the propeller, it'll be ruined and I'll kick your butt.

JASON: So he starts to solder and I think, "Maybe this will make up for the time I cut his finger off." And he stops soldering . . .

CHRIS: This isn't gonna make up for the time you cut my finger off!

JASON: So, I'm standing there holding it, and the metal starts dripping down on my fingers. *(bounces up and down as if holding something hot)* Chris! Chris! The metal's dripping down on my fingers and it hurts!

CHRIS: Oh! The metal's dripping on your fingers huh? *(vehemently points at his bad finger)*

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JASON: So I held it. For an hour I held it, and for an hour it dripped down off the engine and ran down the knuckles on my left hand. Now, I have liquid metal scars on the knuckles of every finger. *(points at scars and studies them)* Scarred and marred for the rest of my life. And my only consolation is it doesn't look as bad as that big piece of meat he's got on the end of his left hand, you know? And then I thought, "Hey! He sleeps with his door unlocked . . . and he's got nine more good fingers, baby!" *(slams imaginary door)* WAM!

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
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